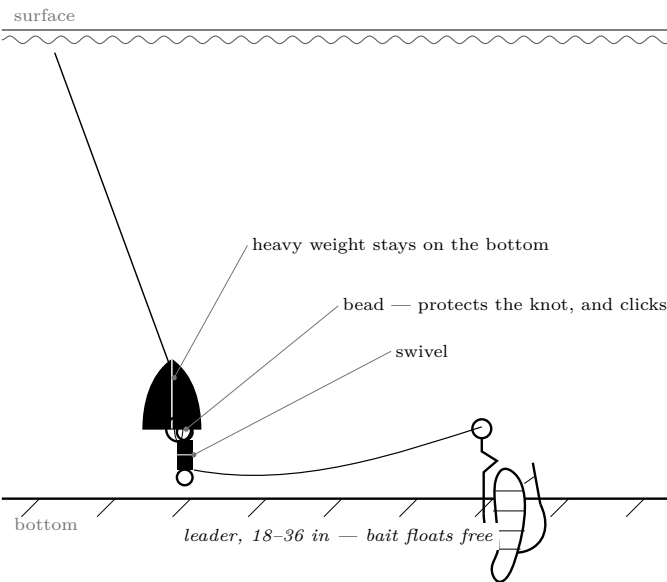


Carolina Rig

The bottom-searching bass rig

Cover a lot of bottom and keep the bait floating just above it



What it does

A heavy weight stays on the bottom and telegraphs exactly what the bottom is made of, while the bait trails behind on a long leader, floating free.

Versus Texas

A Texas rig puts the weight *at* the bait; a Carolina rig separates them. Texas gets into cover; Carolina covers ground and keeps the bait visible.

Components

3/8–3/4 oz weight, glass or brass bead, barrel swivel, 18–36 in leader, offset hook, soft plastic.

The bead

Sits between weight and swivel. It protects the knot and it clicks — an audible attractor on a hard bottom.

Leader length

Short (18 in) in cold water or heavy weed; long (36 in) in clear water and on a clean bottom.

Line

15 lb main, 10–12 lb leader, so a snag breaks off the bait and not the whole rig.

Build it

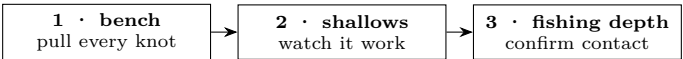
1. Thread the **weight** onto the main line, then the **bead**.
2. Tie the main line to a **barrel swivel**.
3. Tie the **leader** to the other end of the swivel, then the **hook** to the leader.
4. Rig the plastic weedless exactly as for a *see the Texas rig sheet*, or on an open hook if the bottom is clean.

Fish it

Cast long	This is a long-cast rig. The weight carries it, and the long leader means it needs a slow, wide casting stroke or it will tangle.
Drag, do not hop	Sweep the rod sideways, low and slow, to drag the weight across the bottom. Reel up the slack, reposition, sweep again.
Feel the bottom	You are mapping structure by touch. Sand feels smooth, gravel grinds, rock knocks, weeds load and release. Slow down when the bottom changes — that is where fish are.
The bite	Usually a distinct tick or a mushy weight. Reel down until tight, then sweep. Do not snap.
Where	Pine spot 5 on the outside weed edge, and the flats around the base of the bar at 4 . North spots 3 and 4 .

When to use it
When you need to find fish on a big, featureless-looking flat. The Carolina rig is a search tool that happens to catch fish: it tells you where the bottom changes, and bass live where the bottom changes.

Prove the rig



Bench test	Pull main-line knot and leader knot separately; the swivel must turn and the bead must remain above it.
Water test	Drag beside the boat: the sinker should tick bottom while the plastic trails freely without spinning.
Proof at depth	Count distinct bottom taps; no taps means too light, continuous plowing means too heavy.
If it fails	Leader wraps the main line: shorten to 18in or slow the cast. Weed fouls the bait: peg nothing; shorten leader and inspect every retrieve. Change one variable, repeat the same cast or drop, and keep the first setting that restores the expected proof.

Record the adjustment

Try	Depth / distance	Sink count	Observed action	Fish response	Next single change
1					
2					
3					

Questions before another cast

Did the rig reach the intended depth? What visible line, rod-tip, bottom, or lure response proves that? Did the connection and hook point survive the retrieve? Was a follow, bite, snag, or refusal observed rather than assumed? Name one variable to change and one to hold constant. If the observation cannot answer those questions, repeat the same short controlled cast before changing the setup.

☐ Sketch the cast: surface, cover, target depth, line angle, and where the response occurred

Evidence-based verdict ☐ repeat unchanged ☐ alter one variable ☐ retire or repair the rig

Reason and next prediction

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